

Mid-level Bureaucrats and Dictatorships: Detouring, Forcing, and Regime Survival

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Formal Political Theory III

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Research Questions

- **Motivating Question:** How does severe career pressure inside authoritarian security apparatuses shape insiders' responses to dictatorship?
- **The argument:** When officers in authoritarian regimes face blocked careers, they are more likely to either overcomply by detouring or to rebel by forcing.
- **Research Question:** How does private information about regime weakness influence whether insiders choose compliance, detouring, or coup attempts?
- How do these dynamics predict survival of the dictatorship?

This research proposal is a game-theoretic formulation of the recent research by Gläsel and Scharpf (2026).

- Gläbel and Scharpf argues that severe career pressure inside authoritarian regimes can produce two extreme responses:
 - ① detouring: disadvantaged officers with little chance of making a successful career within the security apparatus volunteer even for the most burdensome and psychologically straining tasks
 - ② forcing: coup attempt or violent defection
- A natural formalization is a dynamic Bayesian coordination game with a continuum of bureaucrats.
- The model can be specialized into a global game by introducing a common latent state and private noisy signals.

Players and Actions

- Dictator: D
- Bureaucrats: $i \in [0, 1]$
- Each bureaucrat chooses:

$$A_i = \{N, T, C\}$$

where:

N = Normal Compliance, T = Detouring, C = Forcing (Coup).

Information Structure

Assume the common state $\omega \in \Omega$ is distributed according to an improper uniform prior on $\mathbb{R}$.

Each bureaucrat i observes a private signal

$$s_i = \omega + \epsilon_i,$$

where

$$\epsilon_i \stackrel{iid}{\sim} F$$

and F has full support on $\mathbb{R}$.

Interpretation

Each officer receives a noisy private estimate of regime weakness, which supports global-game style threshold behavior.

Aggregate Behavior

Define aggregate action shares:

$$x_T = \int_0^1 \mathbf{1}\{a_i = T\} di, \quad x_C = \int_0^1 \mathbf{1}\{a_i = C\} di$$

- x_T : share of bureaucrats detouring
- x_C : share of bureaucrats forcing
- the rest of agents do nothing—simply keep their heads down.

Core idea:

The regime response depends on these aggregated actions.

Bureaucrat Payoffs Structures

Let bureaucrat i 's utility depend on the action chosen and the realized regime response.

Define it explicitly by action:

$$U_i(N \mid \omega) = 0$$

$$U_i(T \mid \omega) = \delta - \kappa - \phi x_T$$

$$U_i(C \mid \omega) = \begin{cases} R - \chi, & x_C - \alpha x_T \geq \omega, \\ -P - \chi, & x_C - \alpha x_T < \omega. \end{cases}$$

where $\delta > 0$ is the benefit of detouring as a loyalty signal, $\kappa > 0$ is the cost of detouring (e.g. more psychological burden for doing brutal jobs), $\phi > 0$ is a penalty for too many detouring agents, $R > 0$ is the payoff from successful forcing, $P > 0$ is the punishment from failed forcing, $\chi > 0$ is the fixed cost of forcing, and $\alpha \in (0, 1)$ quantifies how much the share of detouring agents protect the regime from coup attempts.

Forcing Incentives

Forcing is chosen when it dominates both normal compliance and detouring:

$$EU_i(C \mid s_i) \geq EU_i(N \mid s_i)$$

and

$$EU_i(C \mid s_i) \geq EU_i(T \mid s_i).$$

Since

$$EU_i(C \mid s_i) = \Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T \geq \omega \mid s_i)(R - \chi) + \Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T < \omega \mid s_i)(-P - \chi),$$

we can rewrite:

$$EU_i(C \mid s_i) = \Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T \geq \omega \mid s_i)R - \Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T < \omega \mid s_i)P - \chi \quad (1)$$

$$\geq \delta - \kappa - \phi \mathbb{E}[x_T \mid s_i]. \quad (2)$$

Notice in the above inequality, since $\omega = s_i - \epsilon_i$, we have

$$\Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T \geq \omega \mid s_i) = \Pr[\epsilon_i \geq s_i - (x_C - \alpha x_T)] = 1 - F(s_i - (x_C - \alpha x_T))$$

We simplify the condition to

$$R - (R + P)F(s_i - (x_C - \alpha x_T)) - \chi \geq \delta - \kappa - \phi \mathbb{E}[x_T \mid s_i].$$

Detouring Incentives

Detouring is chosen when it dominates both normal compliance and forcing:

$$EU_i(T \mid s_i) \geq EU_i(N \mid s_i) = 0$$

and

$$EU_i(T \mid s_i) \geq EU_i(C \mid s_i).$$

Since

$$EU_i(T \mid s_i) = \delta - \kappa - \phi \mathbb{E}[x_T \mid s_i],$$

we can rewrite:

$$\delta - \kappa - \phi \mathbb{E}[x_T \mid s_i] \geq \Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T \geq \omega \mid s_i)R \quad (3)$$

$$- \Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T < \omega \mid s_i)P - \chi. \quad (4)$$

Detouring Incentive Conti

Using the signal structure $s_i = \omega + \epsilon_i$, we have:

$$\Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T \geq \omega \mid s_i) = 1 - F(s_i - (x_C - \alpha x_T)),$$

$$\Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T < \omega \mid s_i) = F(s_i - (x_C - \alpha x_T)).$$

we obtain:

$$\delta - \kappa - \phi \mathbb{E}[x_T \mid s_i] \geq [1 - F(s_i - (x_C - \alpha x_T))]R \quad (5)$$

$$- F(s_i - (x_C - \alpha x_T))P - \chi. \quad (6)$$

Summary

Detouring is chosen when loyalty signaling is valuable enough to outweigh its cost and congestion, while forcing is chosen only when the expected payoff from collective rebellion exceeds both compliance and detouring.

Threshold Strategy

The next steps are to find threshold strategies and the critical states of the regime: A natural equilibrium has cutoff rules:

$$a_i = \begin{cases} N, & s_i < \hat{s}_1, \\ T, & \hat{s}_1 \leq s_i < \hat{s}_2, \\ C, & s_i \geq \hat{s}_2. \end{cases}$$

- low signal of regime weakness $\Rightarrow$ normal compliance
- intermediate pressure $\Rightarrow$ detouring
- high signal of regime weakness $\Rightarrow$ forcing

Indifference Conditions

The cutoff thresholds are pinned down by indifference:

$$EU_i(N \mid \hat{s}_1) = EU_i(T \mid \hat{s}_1), \quad EU_i(T \mid \hat{s}_2) = EU_i(C \mid \hat{s}_2).$$

Equivalently:

$$0 = \delta - \kappa - \phi \mathbb{E}[x_T \mid s_i = \hat{s}_1]$$

and

$$\begin{aligned} \delta - \kappa - \phi \mathbb{E}[x_T \mid s_i = \hat{s}_2] &= \Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T \geq \omega \mid s_i = \hat{s}_2)R \\ &\quad + \Pr(x_C - \alpha x_T < \omega \mid s_i = \hat{s}_2)(-P - \chi). \end{aligned}$$

we can also write the second condition as

$$\begin{aligned} \delta - \kappa - \phi \mathbb{E}[x_T \mid s_i = \hat{s}_2] &= [1 - F(\hat{s}_2 - (x_C - \alpha x_T))]R \\ &\quad - F(\hat{s}_2 - (x_C - \alpha x_T))P - \chi. \end{aligned}$$

The first cutoff separates compliance from detouring; the second separates detouring from forcing.

Critical State

Given the cutoff rule, the aggregate forcing rate is:

$$x_C(\omega) = \Pr(s_i \geq \hat{s}_2 \mid \omega) = 1 - F(\hat{s}_2 - \omega).$$

The detouring rate is:

$$x_T(\omega) = \Pr(\hat{s}_1 \leq s_i < \hat{s}_2 \mid \omega) = F(\hat{s}_2 - \omega) - F(\hat{s}_1 - \omega).$$

The critical state $\bar{\omega}$ is defined by:

$$x_C(\omega^*) - \alpha x_T(\omega^*) = \bar{\omega}.$$

Equivalently:

$$1 - F(\hat{s}_2 - \omega^*) - \alpha [F(\hat{s}_2 - \omega^*) - F(\hat{s}_1 - \omega^*)] = \bar{\omega}.$$

Interpretation

The regime survives if effective rebellion pressure stays below the latent weakness threshold; it collapses otherwise.

Conclusion

- The strategic situation described by Gläbel and Scharpf is well captured by a dynamic Bayesian coordination game with a continuum of bureaucrats.
- The model uses only ω as the latent state and s_i as the private signal.
- The equilibrium is a three-region threshold rule in private signals.
- Detouring and forcing emerge as distinct responses to regime weakness.

Gläbel, C. and Scharpf, A. (2026). *Making a Career in Dictatorship: The Secret Logic behind Repression and Coups*. Oxford University Press.